

Callorhinus ursinus

Northern fur seal

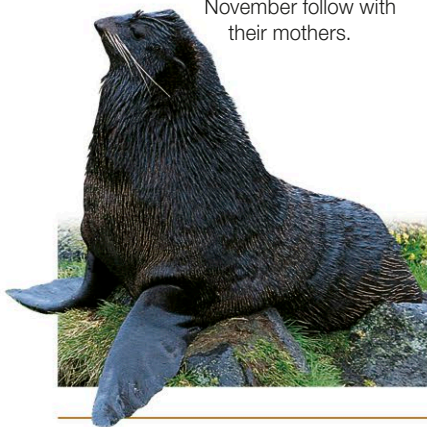


Length Up to 7 ft (2.1 m)
Weight 400–600 lb (180–270 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Vulnerable

Location North Pacific



The male northern fur seal is brown-gray, while females and juveniles are silver-gray above and red-brown below, with a gray-white chest patch. The front flippers are long and appear “cut off” at the wrist. The diet includes many fish, and also birds such as loons and petrels. Most populations are migratory, with adult males heading south in August. The young stay on land for 4 months and by November follow with their mothers.



Arctocephalus pusillus

Brown fur seal



Length 4–7½ ft (1.2–2.3 m)
Weight Up to 778 lb (353 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location Southern Africa, S.E. Australia, Tasmania



Brown fur seals from off South Africa tend to be a darker gray-brown than Australian individuals, and they dive twice as deep (to 1,300 ft/400 m). The young are about 28 in (70 cm) long and weigh 13 lb (6 kg) when born, in November–December. They play in “nursery” tidal pools, while the mothers feed at sea for several days at a time.



Arctocephalus gazella

Antarctic fur seal



Length 4–6½ ft (1.2–2 m)
Weight 50–450 lb (22–204 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location Antarctic and subantarctic waters



The mane of the male Antarctic fur seal is accentuated by extra muscle and fat, deposited under the skin. He is dark gray-brown, while the female is midgray.

Males arrive at their breeding islands in November and compete for territories in which they can mate with about 5 females. Almost exterminated by fur hunting in the 19th century, this species is now recovering despite increased fishing of krill, a major component of its diet.



Zalophus californianus

California sea lion



Length Up to 7¾ ft (2.4 m)
Weight 610–860 lb (275–390 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location W. USA



The “performing seal” of marine parks and aquaria, this species rarely strays more than 10 miles (16 km) out to sea, and often enters harbors and estuaries for food and shelter. The male is dark brown, and females

and juveniles are a uniform tan color. Males have a peaklike head crest. The main prey is schooling fish such as herring, squid, and sardines, caught on short (2-minute) dives down to about 245 ft (75 m). In “El Niño years,” the California sea lion’s diet switches to whiting, salmon, and also birds such as guillemots. During the breeding season (May–July), males fight for small territories on the beaches and rock pools. However, after 2 weeks, they must swim off to feed, and on return, have to battle to regain a territory. The mother cares for her single pup (rarely 2) for 8 days, then enters a cycle of 2–4 days feeding at sea and 1–3 days suckling on land. This usually lasts for 8 months until the next birth.

Phocarcos hookeri

New Zealand sea lion



Length 6–8¾ ft (1.8–2.7 m)
Weight 200–990 lb (90–450 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Vulnerable

Location Subantarctic islands south of New Zealand



Also called Hooker’s sea lion, this species is restricted to a few islands south of New Zealand. It forages up to 95 miles (150 km) from land and then retires perhaps ¾ mile (1 km) inland, to rest among cliffs or trees. Males are dark brown with silver-gray hindquarters and a shoulder mane; females and juveniles are silvery or brown-gray above, yellowish or tan underneath. The diet includes fish, crabs, penguins, and seal pups.



Otaria byronia

South American sea lion



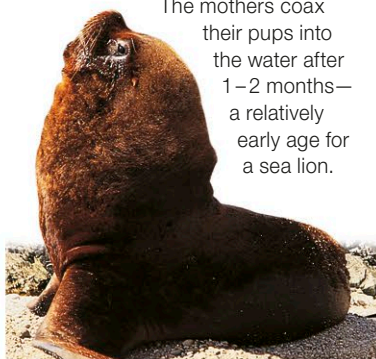
Length 6½–8½ ft (2–2.6 m)
Weight Up to 770 lb (350 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location W., S., and E. South America, Falkland Islands



An enormous, heavy head and brown fur that is paler or yellow on the underside identify this powerful sea lion. The male of this nonmigratory species has a copious shoulder and chest mane, and is twice the weight of the female (as in many sea lions). Its breeding (rookery) areas are used year-round for resting.

The mothers coax their pups into the water after 1–2 months—a relatively early age for a sea lion.



Eumetopias jubatus

Steller’s sea lion



Length Up to 11 ft (3.3 m)
Weight Up to 2,500 lb (1,120 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Endangered

Location North Pacific rim



The largest sea lion, a male Steller’s sea lion has a wide muzzle, a huge head, and a thick neck, and may be 3 times the weight of the female. Both are tawny

or buff-colored, with black flippers furred only on the upper side. Breeding habits resemble those of other sea lions—colonies numbering over 1,000. Steller’s sea lions dive deeply for fish, seals, and otters.

